

The CEO Agenda 2026

What the CEOs behind 10% of global market capitalization see coming next

OLIVER WYMAN
A MARSH BUSINESS | FORUM

NYSE¹



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65%

see competitive disruption as their top opportunity

67%

view a growth lever as their No. 1 priority

58%

cite cost management as a top three priority

M&A aims for scale and capabilities as the AI divide deepens and the talent pyramid shifts

5x

AI-driven cost savings at mega¹ firms versus midsize

3x

AI ROI among AI deployment leaders² versus laggards

2x

Share of CEOs reducing junior roles versus 2025

65%

of CEOs plan M&A to gain scale and 94% plan M&A

53%

say it's too early to assess ROI (up from 41% in 2025)

33%

are shifting toward midlevel roles

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for less than
one year



board
involvement



2025

1. Firms with annual revenue greater than \$10 billion, market capitalization \$30 billion to \$1 trillion (N=59)

2. Those with at-scale AI tools or agents in at least two use cases

3. Spencer Stuart; Oliver Wyman Forum analysis

Note: All forward-looking figures refer to the next one to two years unless otherwise stated

Source: Oliver Wyman Forum x NYSE CEO Survey 2025 and 2026

How are the world's top CEOs responding to the complex set of challenges and opportunities they face today, from geopolitics and artificial intelligence to growth and resilience? And what can they learn from one another in the process?

To answer these questions, the Oliver Wyman Forum and the New York Stock Exchange collected detailed survey responses from 415 chief executives around the world, the most extensive annual survey of its kind and the third in our series. The public and private companies represented here span all major sectors, with the public companies alone accounting for roughly 10% of global market capitalization.

Their responses, though varied, point to a common conviction among CEOs in 2026: This is the time to harness an unprecedented wave of disruption — before it reshapes them. That requires different thinking. Today's leaders no longer have the luxury of tackling priorities one by one. Instead, they must execute in parallel across multiple vectors, from AI and M&A to talent and governance, making interlocking

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Growth remains the overriding priority, but the model is shifting. Two-thirds of CEOs chose a growth lever such as revenue uplift or organic investment as their top objective, while 58% ranked cost management in their top three. Self-funded growth is the dominant play, making cost and productivity a financing engine to capitalize on disruption, not just a defensive response to it.

3

M&A is on almost everyone's to-do list, but the CEOs playing offense are buying capabilities to gain scale and speed. Ninety-four percent of CEOs plan deals in the next year or two and 65% are pursuing industry consolidation, up six points from last year. But M&A is increasingly about buying what takes too long to build — 42% plan to acquire new capabilities and intellectual capital, rising to 54% among the largest companies and above 55% in the sectors where technological change is moving fastest.

4

An AI divide is deepening, with many companies still mired in pilots and planning even as early leaders widen the ROI gap. Two-thirds of companies remain in planning or pilot mode and 53% say it is too early to assess ROI, up from 41% last year. Yet those scaling AI across two or more use cases report roughly twice the ROI, measured in both cost savings and revenue gains. Size is critical, too: Nearly five

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Time horizons are compressing and boards are governing more intensely. CEOs now devote half of all planning efforts to horizons of less than one year, up from 43% in 2025, as 96% report increased board involvement in at least one area.

The companies that are active across more of these vectors simultaneously are starting to pull ahead, in what could be the beginning of a great divergence.

Company size is one key factor. For example, the small and midsize companies in our set, facing consolidation pressure from larger rivals, are pursuing big, transformative M&A deals at a higher rate than the large and mega-size companies we tracked. Midsize companies, despite signaling strong AI investment intent last year, lag both their smaller and larger peers in scaling AI deployment. And size compounds AI advantages in some use cases: 45% of large and mega-size companies have deployed AI at scale in operational efficiency and customer service, roughly double the rate of small companies.

There are regional variations as well. In the Asia-Pacific region, 47% of companies qualify as AI deployment leaders, far ahead of Europe's share (30%), with North America in between (37%). North America, meanwhile, remains the most growth-oriented region among our set. European CEOs, for their part, are most likely to be shrinking the workforce (38% are planning reductions greater than 5%) and are pursuing M&A for geographic expansion more aggressively than peers (54% versus

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Deployment

Process
Product

Technology
Automation
Cost

Talent

Leadership
Workforce
Succession
People
Culture

Growth Investment

Customer
Expansion

Market timing
Organic growth
Supply chain
Innovation
Opportunity
Investors
New market
Revenue
Margin

Change

Transformation
Capital

Efficiency
Debt
Operational
excellence

Geopolitics
Politics
Uncertainty

■ AI ■ Talent and succession ■ Growth ■ Transformation ■ Navigating complexity

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Cost

Leadership

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Succession

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Organic growth

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memory.

We launched this project in 2024 to provide CEOs with useful peer business insights, not just sentiment. Since then, everything has moved at hyperspeed: AI is shortening innovation cycles, competitors are making deals, and geopolitics are shifting quickly. Boards are becoming more engaged in strategy, risk, and leadership decisions and are heaping pressure on CEOs not just to ask the right questions but to answer them: How do we grow or position ourselves for advantage? How do we fund those efforts? What is the proper capital allocation? Do we buy or build speed and AI capabilities to capture opportunities? How do we respond to a new wave of AI-enabled and AI-first competitors? Are the new risk exposures we might add prudent or perilous?

How do we redesign our operating model around the realities of compressed time horizons, increasingly active governance, and shifting workforce structures?

CEOs' approaches might vary by company size, sector, or geography, but these leaders are finding common cause in trying to solve one of the trickiest strategy puzzles in recent memory.

In 2026, advantage comes from converting disruption and speed into performance — without creating fragility. The CEOs who get that balance right will do more than keep pace; they'll shape what comes next. The chapters that follow show how.

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Responding to disruption with growth strategies, business transformation, and M&A

Conditions are forcing CEOs to rewrite the rules of leadership practically in real time. Technological change, disruptive business models, and elevated geopolitical and macroeconomic uncertainty are roiling the competitive environment — while more assertive boards demand a faster pace of strategic decision-making. Most chief executives are taking advantage of the disruption with M&A, revenue growth, and business transformation.

Acquisitions are a preferred means of bolstering competitiveness, with most survey participants expecting M&A deals in the next year or two. It's notable that CEOs who view competitive disruption as a top three opportunity are more than twice as likely to plan large-scale, transformative deals (39% versus 18% of their peers).

AI also is considered one of the leading opportunities, but with a fresh twist. It is rapidly evolving from a technology predicted to reduce costs into a growth driver by enabling companies to provide customers with AI-assisted products and services. Of CEOs who selected AI deployment among their top three opportunities, 62% said it is contributing equally to growth and cost efficiency while 17% see it primarily as a growth driver. Our conversations with CEOs reinforce this finding: Large enterprises increasingly see AI as a way to close the gap with tech-native startups that once held a clear technological edge. (In our analysis, we define large companies as those with

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their top opportunity, followed by talent (50%) and AI (45%).

CEOs see competitive disruption as the top opportunity and macroeconomic conditions as the top threat

Factors that CEOs view as a top three business opportunity and/or threat (% of CEOs)

Top opportunities

Top threats

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three opportunity, 12 points above the average, suggesting they are looking past near-term uncertainty and see favorable conditions in the future. Data collection for this report ran from January 12 to March 13, 2026, a period bookended by the World Economic Forum's annual meeting in Davos and intensifying conflict in the Middle East.

Also notable is a sharp drop in concern about the regulatory environment, which could enable CEOs to pursue growth. Two years ago, 68% of NYSE-listed company CEOs said regulation was a top threat to their business; today, amid a pronounced trend toward deregulation, especially in the United States, that figure is 34% in North America (equal across NYSE-listed and private companies) and just 19% in Asia-Pacific. European CEOs remain the most regulation-conscious, with 42% citing it as a top threat even as deregulatory agendas gain traction across Europe.

CEOs are self-funding growth with cost management strategies

The era of leverage-fueled expansion is giving way to a discipline-first growth model. With roughly one-third of all outstanding corporate bond debt maturing by 2027, according to the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development, and potentially needing to be refinanced at materially higher rates, CEOs are prioritizing cost management to free up resources to drive growth.

Download the full report here: [Download the full report here](#)

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No. 1 priority (unchanged from 2025), while 58% cited cost management among their top three priorities (similar to 2025) as CEOs continue to self-fund many of their investments.

CEOs have sharpened their focus on self-funded growth

Priorities for increasing shareholder value, 2026 (% of CEOs) and change from 2025 (percentage points)

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Sharper focus this year on self-funded growth

Revenue uplift (pricing, customer loyalty, and other revenue drivers)	27	-1 =	50	+2 ↑
Organic investment in new revenue streams	16	+3 ↑	34	+1 =
Cost management and operational excellence	13	+1 =	58	+3 ↑
Long-term business transformation and reinvention	13	0 =	37	+8 ↑
Acquisitions and partnerships	11	-1 =	41	+2 ↑
Technology and AI deployment	6	-1 =	36	+4 ↑

Less focus on capital efficiency, cash flow, and returning capital

Capital efficiency and cash flow management	5	-2 ↓	15	-12 ↓
Returning capital to shareholders	4	-1 =	17	-9 ↓

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When ranking their number one priority, 67% of CEOs choose a growth driver

67

33

= About the same ↑ Higher this year ↓ Lower this year

■ Growth drivers ■ Value drivers ■ Hybrid drivers

Note: Sum of totals for top 3 priorities is greater than 100% because each CEO selected and ranked 3 options; other sums may not add to 100 due to rounding

Question: "What are your top 3 priorities for increasing shareholder value in the next 1 to 2 years?" (2025 N=165, 2026 N=415)

Source: Oliver Wyman Forum x NYSE CEO Survey 2025 and 2026; Oliver Wyman Forum analysis

Most chief executives are taking advantage of disruption with M&A, revenue growth, and business transformation.

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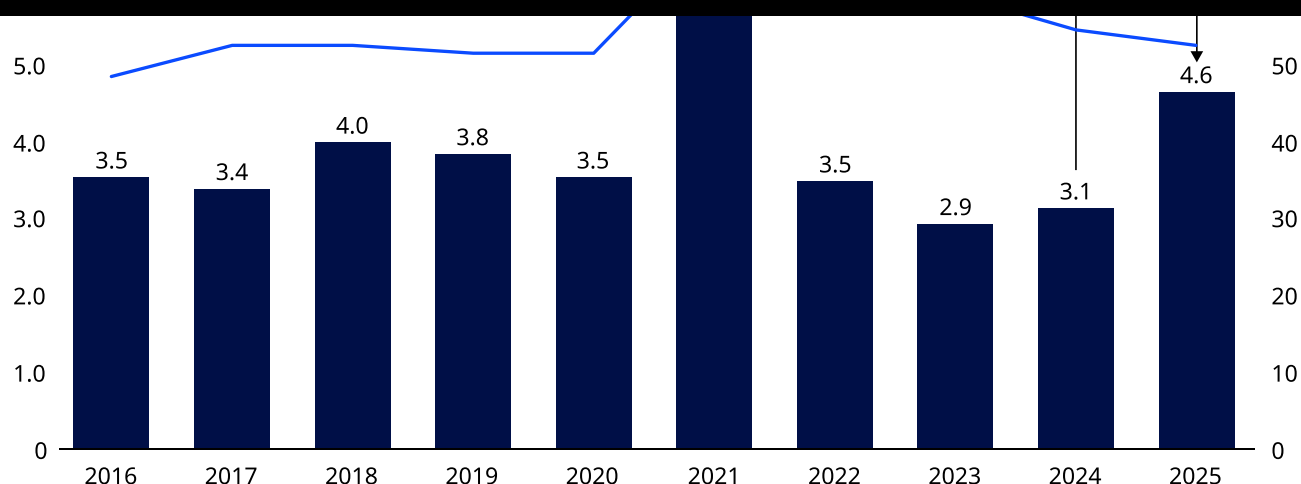


larger, transformative deals. Strategies vary by company size: Bosses of midsize companies lean into bolt-ons and scale-building (58%), while smaller companies, facing consolidation pressure from above, are pursuing larger deals at a higher rate (37%) than the 33% cited by CEOs of midsize companies and the 23% cited by CEOs of large companies. In general, though, the trend is to deepen positions rather than make cross-sector bets: Nearly two-thirds of would-be dealmakers plan to consolidate within their existing industry, up six points from 2025.

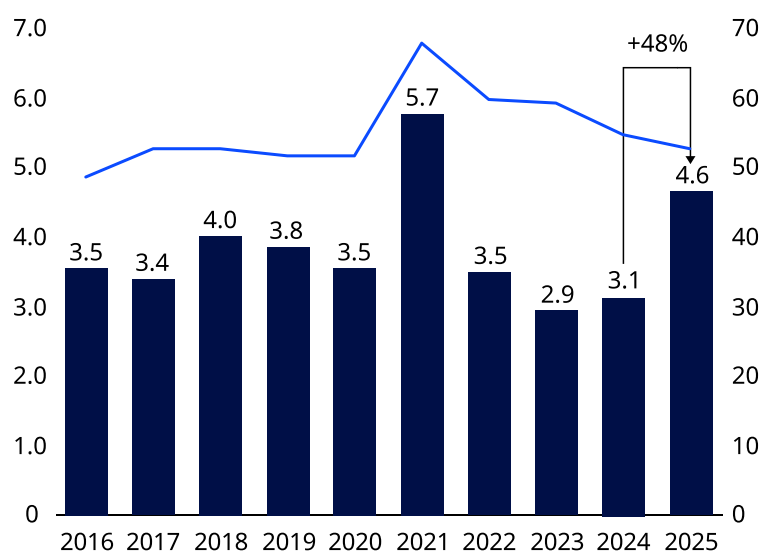
Global M&A deal value rebounded, driven by larger deals

Global M&A deal value (\$ trillions) and number of deals (thousands), yearly, 2016–2025

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■ Deal value (left axis) — Number of deals (right axis)



■ Deal value (left axis) — Number of deals (right axis)

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building, and is sometimes more effective, setting companies up to leapfrog the competition.

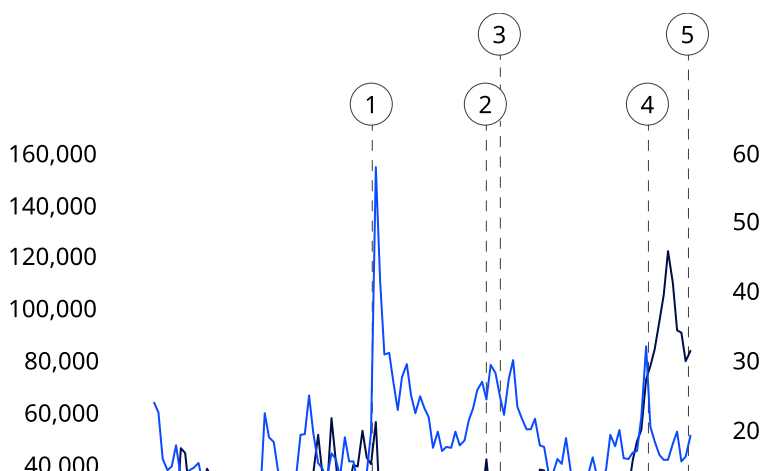
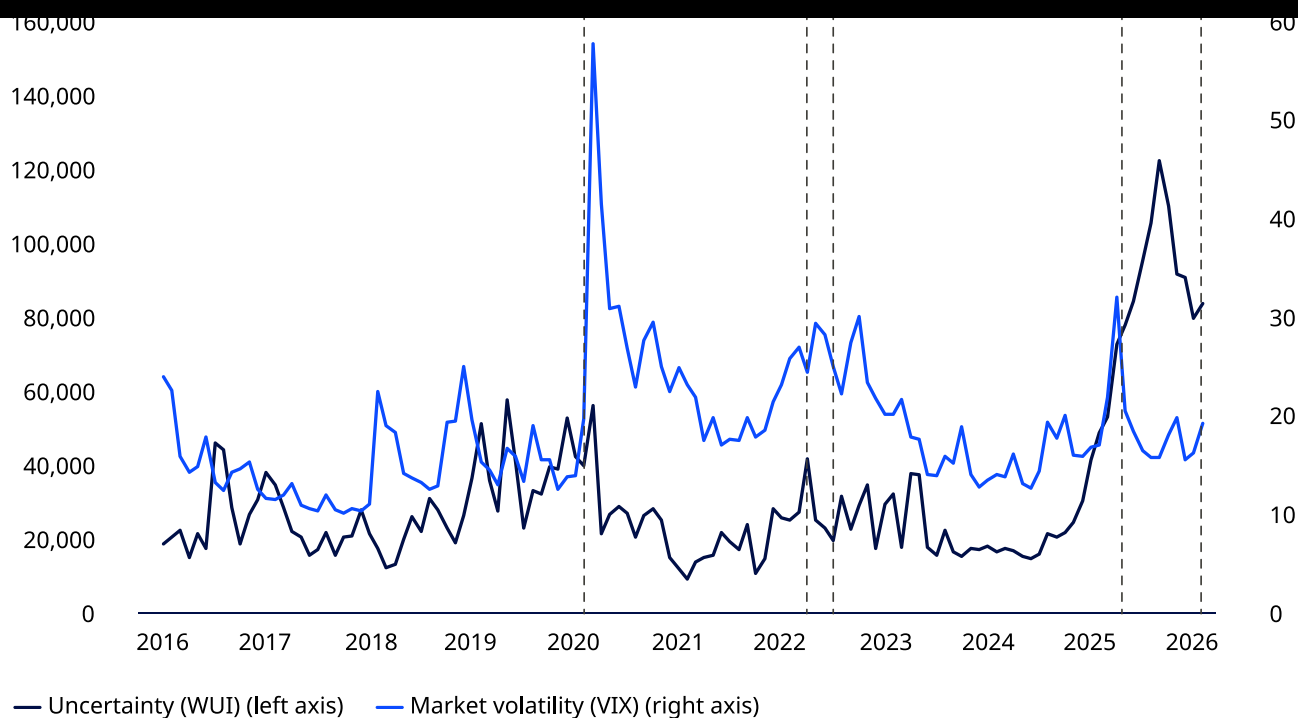
65% of CEOs plan M&A to gain scale through industry consolidation (up from 59% in 2025), while 42% are acquiring capabilities and intellectual capital.

Speed and complexity

Time horizons are compressed but long-term planners outperform on resilience, AI

At a time when economic and geopolitical uncertainty, rapid technological change, and market volatility cloud the future, CEOs are focused on the short term. Half of

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planning horizons of less than one year, up from 43% in 2025.

Small-company CEOs are the most constrained, spending 54% of their time on sub-one-year planning, compared with 42% for leaders at the largest companies. That short-term pressure has a mirror image: Large-company leaders spend 26% of their time on horizons of five years or more, versus just 16% at small companies. Technology, media, and telecom bosses operate on the most compressed timelines of any industry, dedicating only 16% of their time to horizons of five years or more — five percentage points below the average — even as they drive much of the innovation that is accelerating change for everyone else. Energy, natural resources, and utilities CEOs are the most long-term-oriented industry cohort, devoting 27% of their time to horizons of five years or more.

The CEOs who take the longest view see the most opportunity — a pattern that held in both 2025 and 2026. Compressed time horizons, while understandable, might come at the cost of strategic clarity. Our data show that long-horizon planners are making markedly different choices, from supply chains to dealmaking to AI.

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The top increases are in areas core to the board mandate: strategy and governance (61%), executive performance and succession (35%), and risk management (34%). This may help some CEOs succeed, but it also is a moment when leadership continuity is under pressure: 11% of CEOs were replaced in 2025, producing the youngest cohort on record in data from Spencer Stuart. New CEOs were 54 years old on average (down from 56 in 2024) and average tenure for departing CEOs in this database was 8.5 years (down from 9.2 years in 2024).

AI strategy and oversight came in sixth place among 10 categories of increasing board priorities. That suggests many boards already feel adequately briefed on AI and trust executive leadership teams to hold the steering wheel.

96% of CEOs report increased board involvement in at least one area, up six percentage points from 2025.

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Macro and geopolitical risks drive crisis management and supply-chain resilience

Macroeconomic conditions are the most prominent threat among CEOs globally, with 57% ranking it in their top three, followed by geopolitics and trade policy (41%) and the competitive environment (38%). But the risk radar varies sharply by geography, especially when CEOs rank their top threat.

North American CEOs are most worried about macroeconomic conditions, with 30% flagging it as their No. 1 threat — well ahead of 23% in Europe and 19% in Asia-Pacific. European CEOs are disproportionately preoccupied with domestic politics and the regulatory landscape, with 20% citing these as their biggest concern versus 8% in Asia-Pacific.

For leaders of mega-size organizations, whose international exposure amplifies every shock, geopolitical risks register seven points above the global average.

Cybersecurity is also climbing the agenda: 39% of AI deployment leaders (companies with at-scale AI deployment in at least two use cases) now rank it as a top-tier threat, seven points above the average — reflecting the heightened security risks and the trust at stake that come with moving AI past the pilot phase. Companies are responding: 65% of large-firm CEOs are strengthening business continuity and crisis management, with 45% planning to reconfigure supply chains. Proactive

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Artificial intelligence

Most firms are planning or piloting with AI while large firms lead on deployment

Three and a half years after the launch of ChatGPT changed how people work, shop, and compete, the question is no longer whether companies should bet big on AI but how quickly they can move from experimentation to deployment at scale.

More than 90% of companies are at least piloting AI in key areas, including employee productivity, operational efficiency and back office, and analytics and insights. Yet 67% remain primarily in pilot or planning stages. Per use case, on average less than 3% of companies have deployed autonomous agents at scale and 18% on average have deployed AI-assisted tools at scale.

Deployment is most advanced in the more straightforward use cases: operational efficiency, employee productivity, and customer service, where a quarter of companies are using AI at scale. It lags by 10 percentage points in risk and compliance and strategic planning — high-stakes domains where the cost of error is significant and regulatory scrutiny is elevated.

Progress also varies substantially by company size. Roughly 45% of large companies

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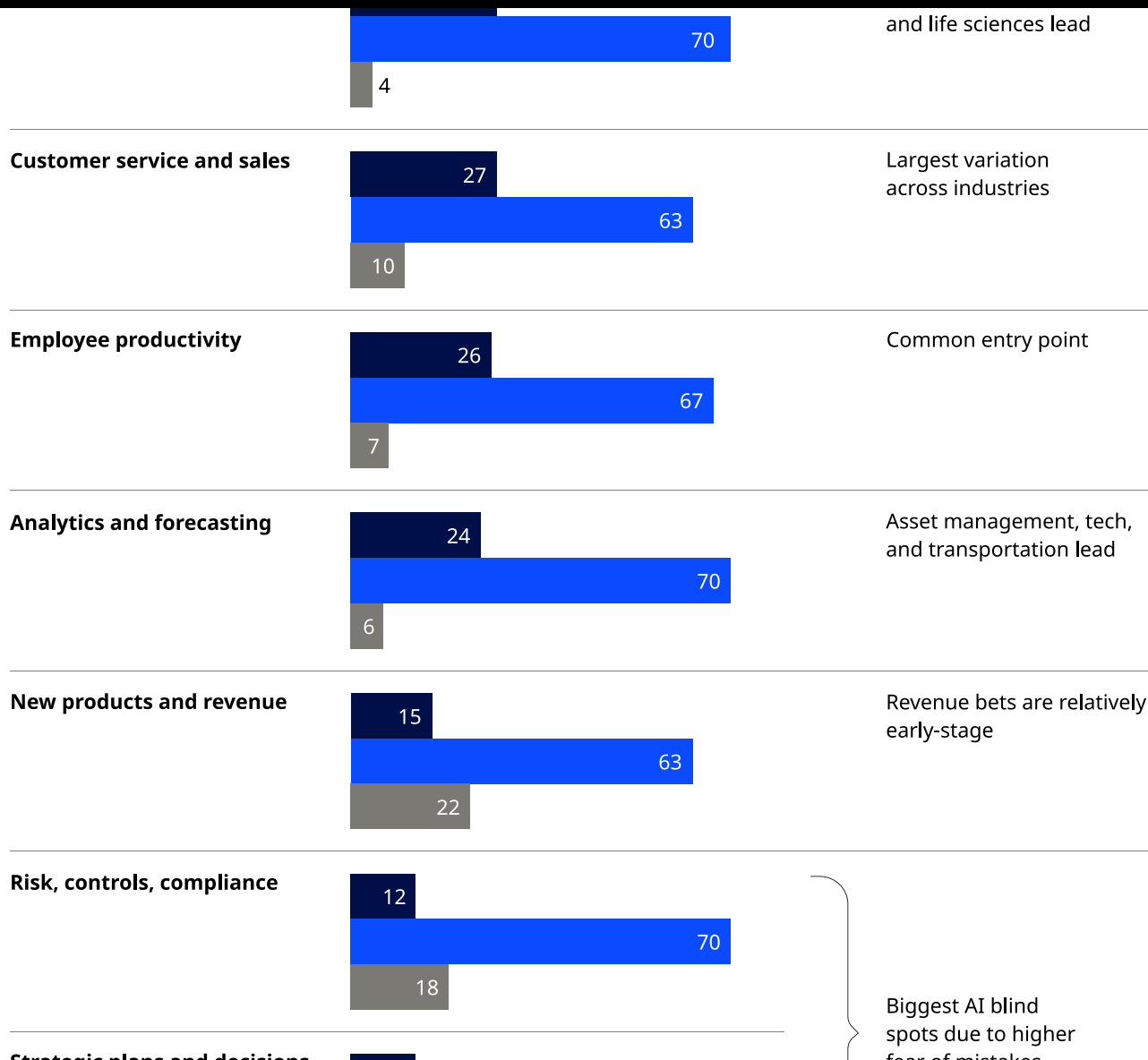
Larger firms invested more aggressively over the past two years in pursuit of market leadership and now report higher at-scale AI deployment, particularly in efficiency and productivity use cases. Scale drives investment, and investment drives deployment.

67% of CEOs are still primarily planning or piloting AI deployment rather than deploying at scale.

Operations, customer service, and productivity are the top deployed AI use cases

Level of AI maturity at respondents' organizations, by use case (% of CEOs)

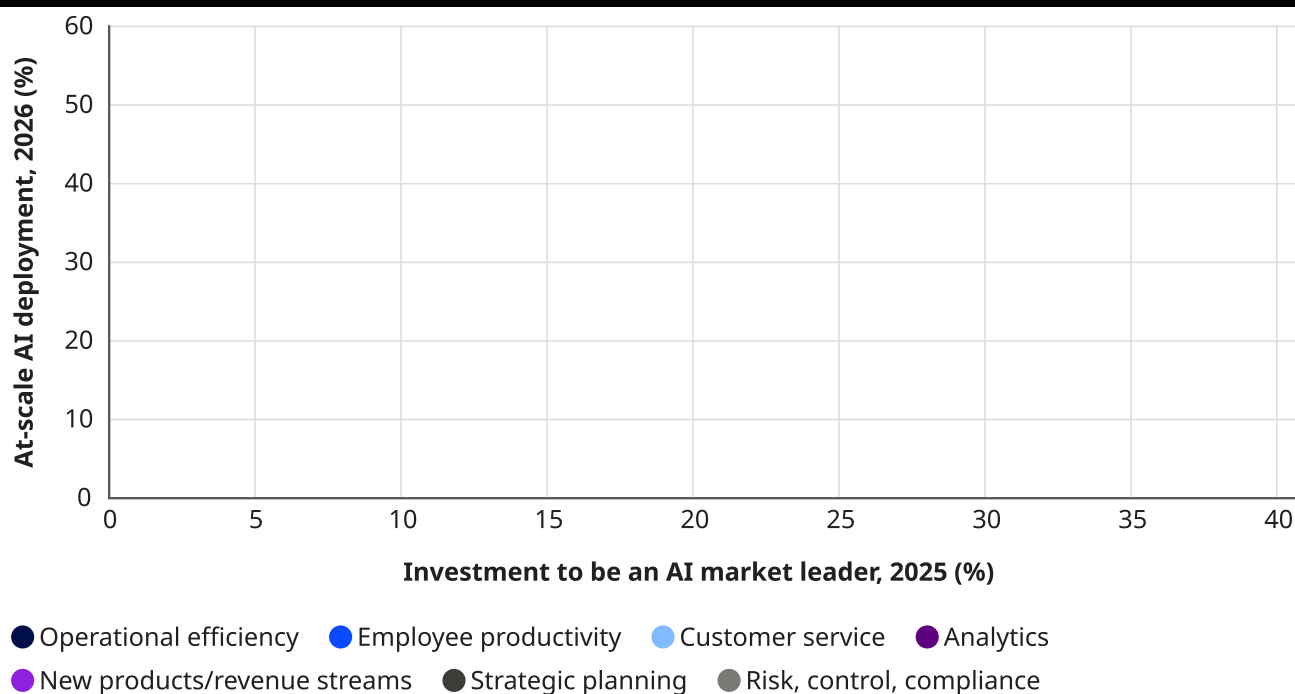
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Questions: "What stage has your company reached in deploying AI?" (2026, N=415); "To what extent are you investing in AI capabilities across the following areas?" (2025, N=165)

Source: Oliver Wyman Forum x NYSE CEO Survey 2025 and 2026; Oliver Wyman Forum analysis

AI's return on investment has a back-to-earth moment among CEOs

Companies are getting more realistic about the pace of AI deployment and the value they're getting from the technology. The share of CEOs who say it is too early to

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with firm-wide impact above 10%.

The ranks of AI ROI leaders — those reporting enterprise-level cost savings or revenue gains above 10% — also have declined, dropping to 12% from 17% in 2025. The decrease primarily reflects less progress than expected on revenue. At our CEO roundtables last year, that 17% number generated skeptical feedback. This year's more modest number appears to be another sign of CEOs adjusting their AI timelines and targets.

Size appears to be a major factor in generating returns to date: Nearly five times as many mega-size companies and twice as many large companies report AI-driven cost savings above 10% compared to their midsize counterparts. Revenue generation remains elusive across the board, though, with just 5% of CEOs globally seeing gains above 10%.

Performance varies significantly by sector, too, with technology, media, and telecom companies pulling decisively ahead on ROI. Twenty-three percent of these tech respondents report cost savings above 10%, while 9% have unlocked revenue gains of more than 10% — both almost double the global average.

Insurance and asset management is a standout on scaling AI tools for analytics, forecasting, and insights (39% of those companies, outperforming tech's 32% rate).

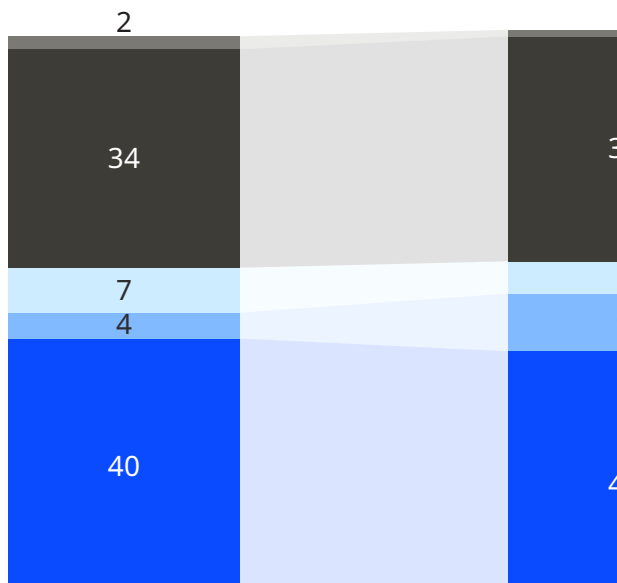
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slower and more difficult than early enthusiasm suggested.

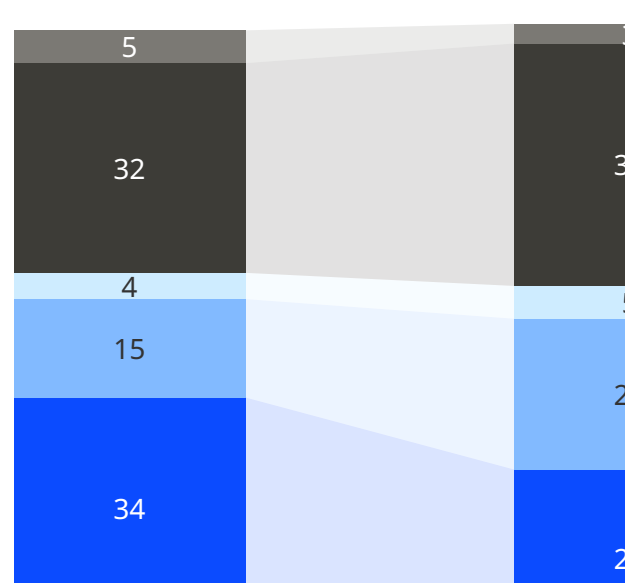
CEOs are more sober on AI cost savings and revenue impact compared with 2025

Extent to which companies see enterprise-wide financial impact from AI, 2025 and 2026 (% of CEOs)

AI-driven cost savings



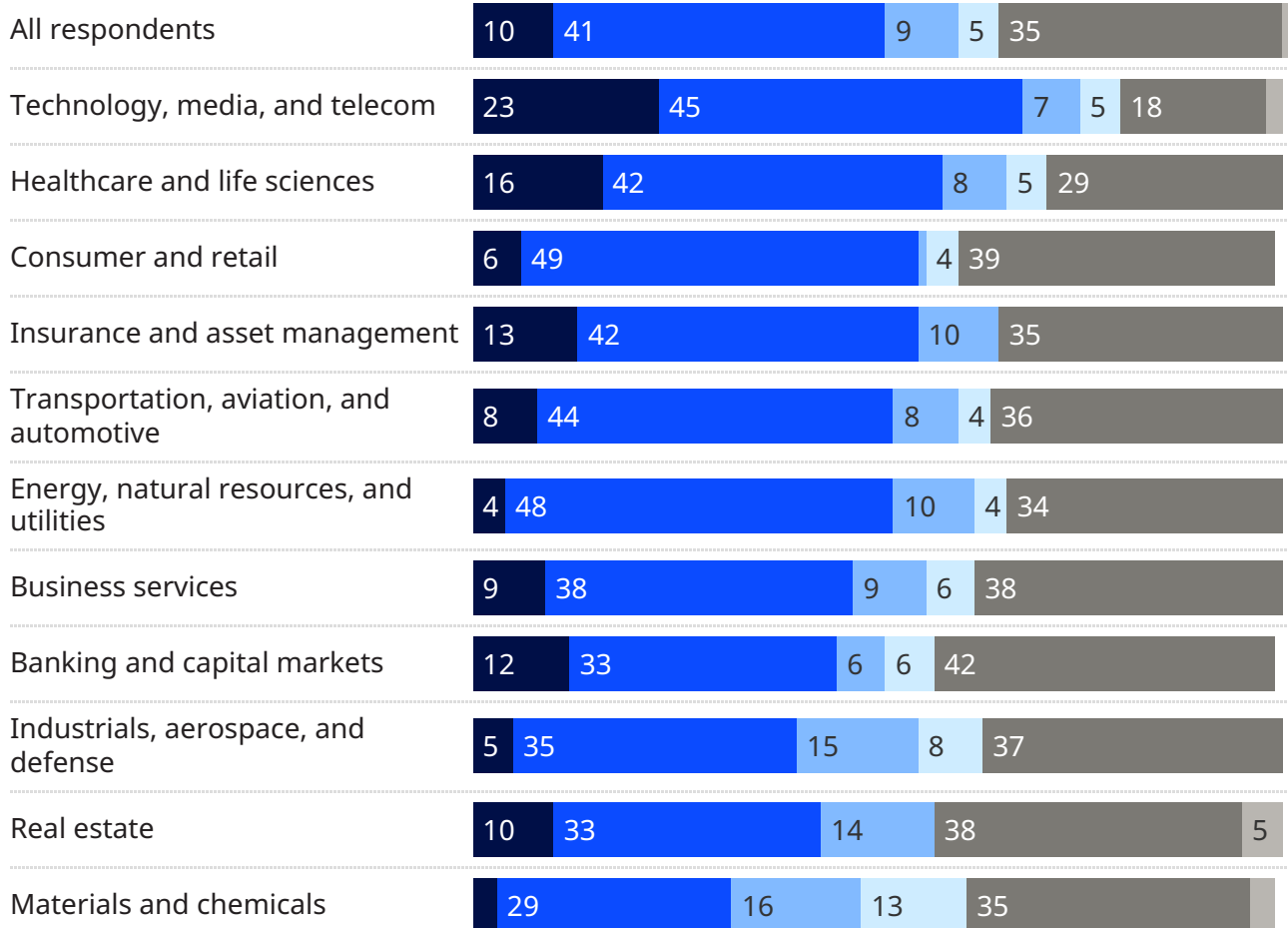
AI-driven revenue generation



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AI-driven cost savings

AI-driven revenue generation



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drives ROI.

In terms of geography, Asia-Pacific is setting the pace. Forty-seven percent of companies in that region qualify as AI deployment leaders, 17 percentage points greater than Europe. Asia-Pacific's edge is particularly pronounced in strategic planning, where 17% have deployed AI at scale, outpacing North America (12%) and Europe (7%) by significant margins. The region's lead is not accidental: Asia-Pacific operates in a more cost-competitive environment, shaped by the rise of powerful open-source models that have reduced the cost of enterprise-wide AI adoption. The pattern across size, sector, and geography points to the same conclusion: The AI divide is compounding, with each quarter of delayed or botched deployment widening the gap between leaders and the rest of the field.

3x as many AI deployment leaders as laggards report returns meeting or exceeding ROI expectations (49% versus 15%).

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Compared with last year, more CEOs are shifting to midlevel roles even as most plan to hold flat or decrease headcount

Expected change in workforce size and seniority mix in the next two years, 2025 and 2026 (% CEOs)

	2025	2026	Change
Plans for workforce size			
Reduce more than 5%	36	29	-7
Remain flat (within +/- 5%)	31	45	+14
Increase more than 5%	33	26	-7
Plans for workforce pyramid			
Shift toward more junior roles	36	17	-19
Shift toward more midlevel roles	11	33	+22
Shift toward more senior	6	10	+4

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The debate about the bottom of the pyramid is hardly uniform, though, with some opting to invest in their future talent pipeline and hire digitally native, AI-fluent juniors.

Interestingly, AI ROI leaders are shifting toward junior workers at a relatively higher rate (24%) than those still struggling to see returns (17%), suggesting that a contrarian subset of the most advanced AI adopters see the technology increasing the value of entry-level talent rather than replacing it. Still, the dominant trend holds: Twice as many AI ROI leaders overall are shifting away from junior workers (50%) as toward them.

The pyramid shift in North America is less aggressive than the global average, but still represents a large reversal of plans and favors midlevel roles

Expected change in workforce size and seniority mix in the next two years in North America, 2025 and 2026 (% CEOs, matched sample)

	2025	2026	Change
Plans for workforce size			
Reduce more than 5%	33	22	-11

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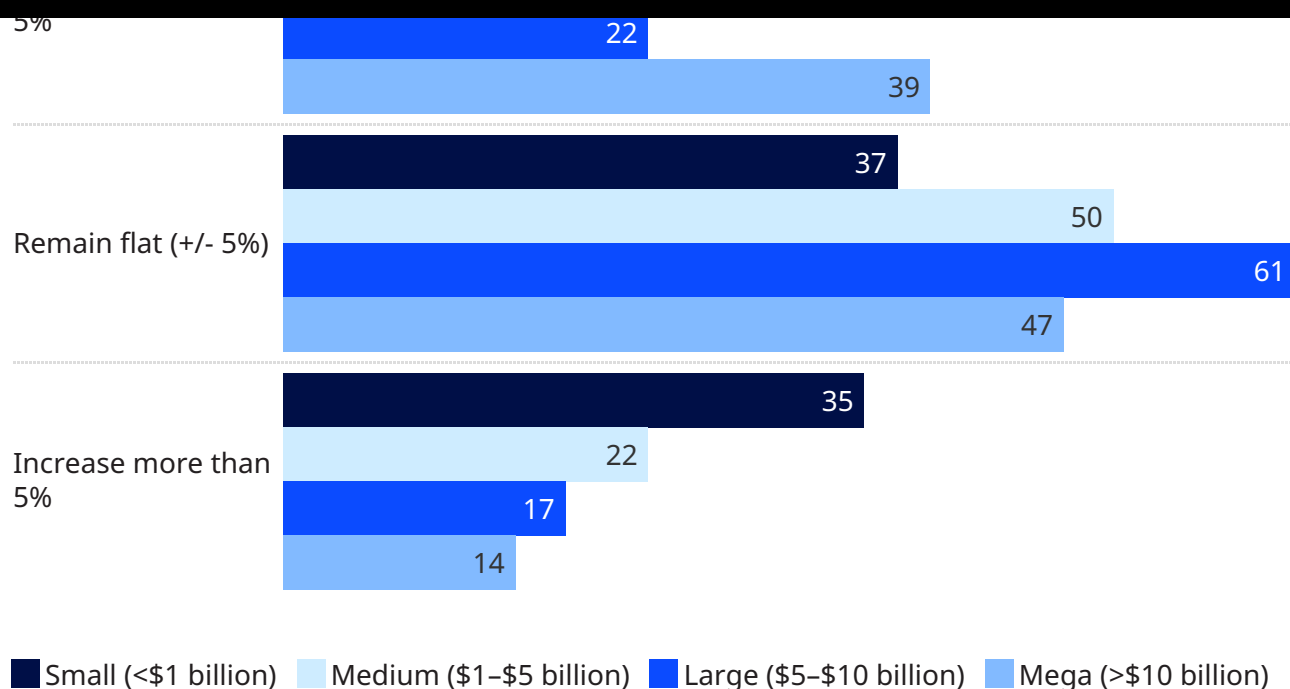
Source: Oliver Wyman Forum x NYSE CEO Survey 2025 and 2026, Oliver Wyman Forum analysis

43% of CEOs plan to reduce junior roles (up from 17% in 2025), while 45% expect to hold overall headcount flat.

Nearly three-quarters of CEOs are keeping workforce levels on hold or cutting

Beyond junior roles, the broader workforce is in a holding pattern. Forty-five percent of CEOs are keeping headcount flat, up 14 percentage points from 2025, while 29% are reducing it by more than 5% in the next one to two years. Together, that means 74% of CEOs are freezing or reducing headcount (up from 67% last year). Where cuts are happening, they are concentrated and deliberate: 39% of mega-size companies plan reductions versus 28% of smaller ones. Europe leads on reductions, with 38% of European CEOs planning cuts, consistent with the region's more value-oriented posture, followed by 33% in Asia-Pacific and 23% in North America. By sector, tech,

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Question: "How do you expect your organization's approach to workforce size to evolve in the next 1 to 2 years?" (N=415)

Source: Oliver Wyman Forum x NYSE CEO Survey 2026; Oliver Wyman Forum analysis

Notably, the CEOs with the longest planning horizons are the most likely to plan headcount reductions. That suggests they expect a structurally leaner organization not as a cost measure but as the destination — the endpoint of an AI-augmented operating model that requires fewer people, deployed differently. But this calculus carries risk. Headcount reduction that outpaces meaningful AI deployment can leave organizations exposed, and overreliance on systems that are still maturing introduces its own vulnerabilities. The harder question — one with which many CEOs

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talent pipeline and company culture will look like in three years if the investment in junior employees is not made today.

Most industries are headed toward similar levels of workforce disruption, but the mix of resizing and reshaping differs

Planned shifts in companies' workforce size and shape in the next two years, by industry, and change from 2025

Industry	CEOs planning flat or decreasing headcount (%)	X	CEOs expecting to change the job pyramid (%)	=	Workforce Disruption Index
Materials and chemicals	74		68		50 ↑
Technology, media, and telecom	70		70		49 ↑
Energy, natural resources, and utilities	79		62		49 ↑
Banking and capital					

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Questions: "How do you expect your organization's approach to workforce size to evolve in the next 1 to 2 years?" (N=415);
"How do you expect your organization's approach to workforce pyramid shape (seniority mix) to evolve in the next 1 to 2 years?" (N=415)

Source: Oliver Wyman Forum x NYSE CEO Survey 2026; Oliver Wyman Forum analysis

Redesigning roles and workflows for AI and prioritizing succession planning

As AI reshapes business models, 38% of CEOs are prioritizing the redesign of roles and workflows, including 49% at large companies, 51% at mega-size companies, and 58% in the insurance and asset management industries. There is a direct connection to expected returns: AI deployment leaders, who excel on ROI, are significantly more likely to be redesigning workflows (49%) than the global average (38%).

Succession planning leads all workforce priorities at 59%, followed by culture (55%) and cross-functional collaboration (48%). By contrast, adapting the employee value proposition sits at the bottom of the priority list, cited by just 17% of survey respondents.

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leadership depth in industries navigating significant structural changes. Long-term thinkers also stand apart here: 69% prioritize succession planning and leadership development, versus 60% of shorter-horizon planners.

Taken together, these workforce findings suggest the central talent question is no longer how many people companies will employ but what skills portfolio is needed and what shape the organization should take to cultivate it.

Today's CEO challenge demands urgency on AI and M&A, longer view on work redesign

Across crucial dimensions of this survey — AI deployment, M&A, workforce redesign — the gap between the companies acting decisively on multiple fronts and those moving tentatively is becoming harder to close. The data paint the portrait of the CEO best positioned for what comes next. Long-horizon thinkers — those who resist the gravitational pull of short-term planning — see more opportunity, prepare more rigorously for shocks, and invest more deliberately in succession. AI deployment leaders who have moved beyond pilots into scaled implementation are generating roughly twice the average returns and are redesigning workflows at materially higher rates. And the companies treating cost discipline not as an end in itself but as an engine to fund growth and investment are the ones turning today's volatility into competitive advantage. These are not separate strategies. The CEOs pulling ahead are managing the interactions between all of them, simultaneously and at speed.

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The 2026 Oliver Wyman Forum and New York Stock Exchange CEO Survey is the largest annual survey of large-company chief executives, capturing the perspectives of 415 CEOs — 266 from public companies and 149 from private companies. The public companies alone represent an estimated \$12 trillion in market capitalization — approximately 10% of all global listed equity at the time of publication. The full sample, including private companies, represents a combined equity value of approximately \$13 trillion.

Fielded from January 12 to March 13, 2026, the survey spans 11 industry categories and reaches CEOs across the entire size spectrum: 59 companies with annual revenues exceeding \$10 billion (each with a market capitalization between \$30 billion and \$1 trillion), 41 with annual revenues between \$5 billion and \$10 billion, 128 with annual revenues between \$1 billion and \$5 billion, and 187 with annual revenues below \$1 billion.

Respondents are concentrated in North America (231) and Europe (132), with additional coverage across Asia-Pacific (36) and other regions (16). Every respondent was either a parent company (group-level) CEO or the CEO of a subsidiary business with at least \$1 billion in annual revenue. All companies below \$1 billion in revenue participated at the group CEO level only.

All forward-looking figures refer to CEOs' plans, decisions, and priorities over the next one to two years unless otherwise stated. Year-over-year comparisons were validated

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from private companies.

Survey respondent characteristics

415

CEOs

10%

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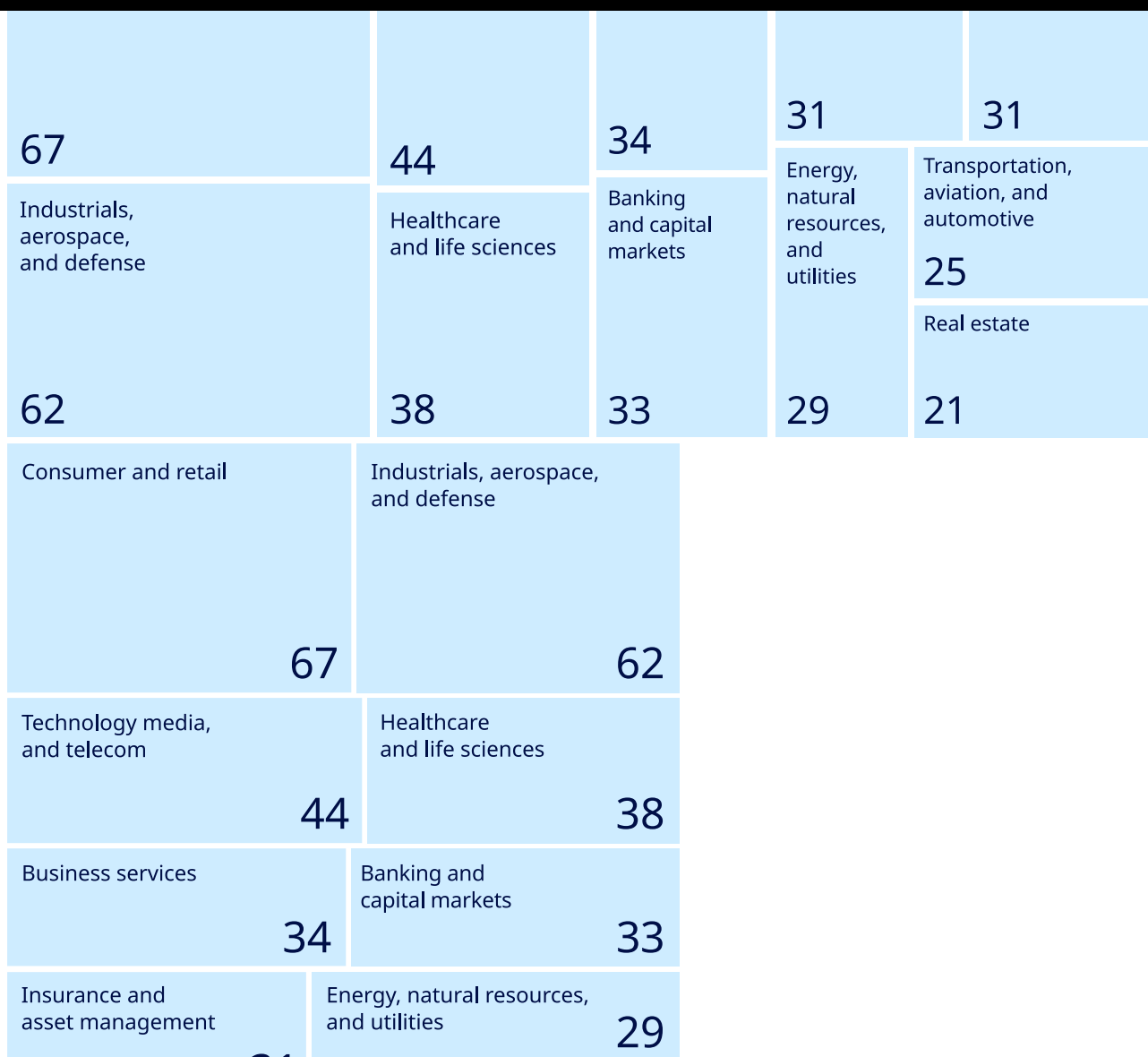
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11

industries

Distribution by industry (number of companies)

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■ North America ■ Europe ■ Asia ■ Rest of the world

Source: Oliver Wyman Forum x NYSE CEO Survey 2026; N=415

Acknowledgments

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